

NATURAL AND NON-HORMONAL METHODS

Natural and Non-Hormonal Options

For those who prefer to avoid synthetic hormones, several non-hormonal contraceptive options are available. These range from evidence-based fertility awareness methods to the copper IUD.

Fertility Awareness-Based Methods (FAMs)

FAMs involve tracking menstrual cycle patterns to identify fertile days and avoiding unprotected intercourse during those times. With perfect use, some FAMs are up to 95–99% effective; typical use rates are lower.

- Calendar/Rhythm method: Estimates fertile days based on past cycle lengths.
- Basal Body Temperature (BBT) method: Tracks the slight rise in resting temperature that occurs after ovulation.
- Cervical mucus method (Billings method): Monitors changes in vaginal discharge to identify fertile days.
- Symptothermal method: Combines BBT and cervical mucus tracking for greater accuracy.
- Digital apps and devices: Some FDA-cleared apps (e.g., Natural Cycles) combine multiple data points for tracking.

Withdrawal Method (Pull-Out Method)

Withdrawal involves the withdrawing the penis from the vagina before ejaculation. With perfect use, it is approximately 96% effective. With typical use, effectiveness drops to approximately 78%. It is more effective when combined with another method such as condoms or FAMs.

Copper IUD - A Non-Hormonal LARC

The copper IUD (Paragard) is the only long-acting non-hormonal contraceptive. Copper ions create an environment that is toxic to sperm. It is over 99% effective and can remain in place for up to 10–12 years. It can also be used as emergency contraception if inserted within 5 days of unprotected intercourse.

Important Considerations

- FAMs require consistent, careful daily tracking — they are less forgiving of irregular cycles.
- FAMs and withdrawal do not protect against STIs.
- Copper IUDs may increase menstrual bleeding and cramping, especially initially.
- FAMs are most effective when learned with proper education from a trained provider.
- Combining methods (e.g., withdrawal + FAM) can improve effectiveness.

Key Takeaway

Non-hormonal methods range from highly effective options like the copper IUD to methods that require significant user effort such as FAMs. The best choice depends on individual health, lifestyle, and commitment to consistent practice.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Fertility awareness-based methods. Trussell, J. (2011).

Contraceptive failure in the United States. Grimes, D. A., Gallo, M. F., Grigorieva, V., Nanda, K., & Schulz, K. F. (2004). Fertility awareness-based methods for contraception.